

SAMPLE LETTERS

Templates You Can Customize and Send

Ready-to-use letter templates for elected officials, property owners, and local media. Customize the bracketed sections for your community.

LETTER 1

To Your Elected Officials

Send to: Mayor, City Council members, County Supervisors, State Representative

Dear [TITLE] [NAME],

I am writing as a resident of [CITY/COUNTY] to urge you to take immediate action regarding the proposed ICE detention facility at [ADDRESS/LOCATION].

A federal contractor is negotiating to convert an industrial warehouse into a detention facility that could house [NUMBER] people. This process has occurred without public notice, without environmental review, and without consultation with local elected officials.

I have three specific concerns:

Infrastructure: The facility at [LOCATION] was designed for approximately [50-100] daytime workers. Housing [NUMBER] people 24 hours a day would place extraordinary strain on our sewage system, water supply, electrical grid, and emergency services. These systems were never designed for residential-scale populations.

Public health: Documented conditions in existing ICE detention facilities include disease outbreaks, contaminated water, and inadequate medical care. A facility of this scale creates public health risks for the surrounding community.

Process: This deal was negotiated in secret. A contract worth [DOLLAR AMOUNT] of taxpayer money should not proceed without public input, environmental review, or consultation with the community that will bear the consequences.

I respectfully ask you to:

1. Introduce a moratorium on detention facilities within [JURISDICTION], following the precedent set by communities in Missouri, Virginia, and Maryland.

2. Request a public hearing on the proposed facility.
3. Issue a formal statement of opposition on behalf of [CITY/COUNTY].

Five communities across America have already stopped these facilities. I urge you to stand with your constituents and do the same.

Sincerely,

[YOUR NAME]

[YOUR ADDRESS]

[YOUR PHONE/EMAIL]

LETTER 2

To the Property Owner

Send to: The owner of the warehouse or industrial property being considered for conversion

Dear [PROPERTY OWNER NAME],

I am writing to you as a member of the [CITY/NEIGHBORHOOD] community regarding your property at [ADDRESS].

We understand that a federal contractor has approached you about leasing or selling your property for use as an ICE detention facility. We urge you to decline this arrangement.

We recognize this may appear to be a straightforward business transaction, but we want to share what we have learned about the impact these facilities have had on other communities:

Facilities of this type are designed to hold 1,500 to 10,000 people in buildings designed for a fraction of that capacity. They overwhelm local sewage, water, and electrical systems. They require significant emergency services support. They generate intense community opposition that can affect surrounding property values and business activity for years.

Property owners in Minnesota, Utah, and Virginia have already walked away from similar deals after learning about the community impact. In each case, the property owner made the right decision — and their community relationships remained intact.

We are not asking you to take a political stand. We are asking you to consider the impact on your neighbors, your community, and your own reputation before proceeding with this transaction.

We would welcome the opportunity to meet with you and share more information.

Sincerely,

[YOUR NAME]

[COMMUNITY GROUP NAME, if applicable]

[CONTACT INFORMATION]

LETTER 3

To Local Media (Letter to the Editor)

Send to: Your local newspaper's letters editor. Keep under 250 words. Most papers publish letters within 1-2 weeks.

Dear Editor,

A federal contractor is secretly negotiating to turn a warehouse at [LOCATION] into an ICE detention facility for [NUMBER] people. Our community was never told.

This warehouse was built for [50-100] daytime workers. Housing thousands of people there 24/7 would overwhelm our sewage system, strain our water supply, and burden our emergency services — infrastructure that our tax dollars built for our community, not for a federal detention operation.

The contract is worth [DOLLAR AMOUNT] of taxpayer money, negotiated without public input or environmental review. Documented conditions in existing ICE facilities include disease outbreaks, contaminated water, and deaths in custody.

Five communities across America have already stopped these facilities. In Missouri, a county passed a five-year moratorium. In Virginia, the Board of Supervisors passed a unanimous resolution. These aren't partisan victories — they're communities standing up for local control.

I urge our elected officials to follow their lead: hold a public hearing, introduce a moratorium, and stand with the residents who will bear the consequences of this facility.

[YOUR NAME]

[YOUR CITY]

LETTER 4

Op-Ed Pitch to Local Newspaper

Send to: The opinion editor at your local paper. If accepted, they'll ask for a 600-800 word piece.

Dear [EDITOR NAME],

I'd like to pitch an op-ed about the proposed ICE detention facility at [LOCATION] in [CITY/COUNTY].

A federal contractor is negotiating to convert an industrial warehouse into a facility housing [NUMBER] detainees. The deal is being done without public notice, environmental review, or consultation with local officials — despite a contract worth [DOLLAR AMOUNT].

I am a [RESIDENT/BUSINESS OWNER/COMMUNITY LEADER] in [NEIGHBORHOOD] and have been organizing community opposition. I can provide specific details about the infrastructure impact (the local sewage system serves [NUMBER] and cannot support thousands of additional residents), the public health risks (based on documented conditions in existing ICE facilities), and the growing bipartisan opposition.

Five communities nationally have already stopped similar facilities. Our community is organizing to be the sixth.

I believe this story matters to [NEWSPAPER NAME] readers because it affects [SPECIFIC LOCAL IMPACT]. I can have the piece ready within [TIMEFRAME].

Thank you for your consideration.

[YOUR NAME]

[YOUR CREDENTIALS/AFFILIATION]

[CONTACT INFORMATION]

Customize everything in [BRACKETS] with your local details. The more specific you are — street addresses, dollar amounts, population numbers, sewage capacity — the more effective your letter will be. Generic letters get ignored; specific letters get results.